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SWOT Assessment: MetricStream IT GRC Solution v6.1, and MetricStream GRC Platform v6.1

Analyzing the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats

Summary

Catalyst

Organizations of almost all types continue to struggle with an increasing burden of compliance pressures from regulations within their operating environment, and the need to achieve the benefits of adherence to standards. Risk also continues to be an increasing focus, especially as the speed and severity of consequences arising from newer security threats is alarmingly greater than ever before. Rather than addressing these issues in a disparate way, organizations need to take a broad view of how they can best deal with governance, risk, compliance (GRC) needs, and ensure that their IT function provides a solid foundation for strong IT governance and risk management, as well as addressing wider GRC needs across operational areas.

Key messages

- MetricStream IT GRC Solution covers a wide range of requirements across risk management, security threats and vulnerabilities, IT asset management, business continuity, cloud governance, and standards compliance
- An extensive range of foundational functions, delivered by MetricStream GRC Platform, also includes management of policies, audits, issues, incidents, metrics, and integration frameworks, as well as powerful reporting capabilities.
- These solutions have in-built content and configuration tools (AppStudio) to help customers reduce the cost of building their GRC capabilities, supporting a very broad range of the leading standard frameworks, regulations, and control mechanisms.
- Customers with MetricStream GRC Platform can take advantage of the company's many other business- and IT-oriented solutions, purchased separately, facilitating an integrated approach across IT and business GRC requirements.

Ovum view

As well as the IT GRC solutions covered by this assessment, MetricStream provides others for industry-specific needs, and modules that can add functionality to cater for more specific or advanced needs relating to particular business processes. The vendor is aiming to make GRC more pervasive within customer organizations – enabling its solutions to be used more widely in business units, so that more business value is gained, rather than GRC being operated in a compartmentalized way. Along with its approach of enabling automation of GRC processes wherever possible, devolving responsibility in this way will also increase efficiency and timeliness within organizations as they deliver on their GRC responsibilities.

MetricStream is a well-established and prominent provider in the GRC market place, with a significant customer base across many market sectors. It adds to the strength of its solution range by innovating highly effectively – for example, providing outreach such as well-supported developer and customer communities and regional events, and in particular providing an 'express' solution and SaaS-based option which facilitate faster and potentially smaller-scale deployment. It also has excellent partner support across global regions, helping to allow customers to engage with the expertise needed to define and achieve their optimum deployment options.

Recommendations for enterprises

Numerous internal and external drivers are continuing to force organizations to see definition of their GRC approach as a truly strategic decision. Importantly, greater overall organizational effectiveness really can result, rather than 'doing' GRC to tick a box. Organizations making these considerations must take into account the value that a leading solution can deliver by embedding best practice and industry-standard content. As a strong contender in the market, MetricSteam's solution covers a very extensive range of requirements relating to IT GRC, and importantly provides the basis for integrating GRC information across areas of IT requirements, and extension of that integration to other MetricStream GRC solutions. Limitations on the scale of investment available for GRC solutions affect some organizations' choices, and MetricStream can help here with the availability of its cloud-based 'express' solution option.

SWOT analysis

Strengths

MetricStream is a leading and specialist GRC vendor

Customers investing in GRC solutions particularly need supplier expertise. MetricStream provides best practice and support for leading standard frameworks, regulations, and control mechanisms within its IT GRC solution, and advisory help via its strong and extensive partner network.

The IT GRC solution supports an extensive range of requirements

MetricStream IT GRC Solution provides an impressive breadth of coverage of requirements, using embedded content to cater for a range of disparate processes, standards, frameworks, and controls that represent additional value and which can reduce implementation costs.

The solutions provide an extensive range of foundational facilities

The broad range of GRC functions all use shared underlying capabilities such as workflow, reporting, surveys, and data integration with third-party solutions. These are well integrated, and provide repeated value as customers add to their usage of the GRC functionality available.

MetricStream GRC Platform supports GRC footprint expansion

MetricStream follows a GRC platform approach for deploying the IT GRC solution which allows organizations to extend their GRC footprint into associated areas such as vendor management, operational risk management, and audit management, with lower additional cost due to the existing investment.

Weaknesses

Out-of-the-box integration with third-party solutions needs to be expanded

The range of formal technology partnerships represented within the GRC solutions needs to be expanded. A greater focus here would provide more value for customers, in the way that these solutions' otherwise extensive capabilities and integration features achieve. Particularly in the area of security, this should be an area of investment by MetricStream, to further ease customers' solution implementations. Ovum does, however, recognize that bespoke integration with many third-party

solutions is not problematic, and the vendor can provide many examples of this being achieved successfully.

Solution cost and related implementation effort is comparatively greater

Inevitably, a perception can exist that the extensive range of capabilities within the MetricStream GRC solutions is directly reflected in high solution costs relative to some competitors' offerings. This may be so, given the range of configuration options and range of solution available. Specialist knowledge and in-depth analysis is necessary in order to represent the potential return on investment in a leading GRC solution, and incorporate this within a business case, as no two organizations are alike in terms of the changes necessary and the benefit landscape. MetricStream should focus on spreading awareness of this to potential new customers, and to existing customers who might yet gain greater value from their existing or future investment in the vendor's solutions.

Opportunities

The cloud-based 'express' solution provides potentially less expensive, and more rapid, implementation options

The cloud-based 'express' version of MetricStream IT GRC solution provides an option for organizations that might be unwilling or unable to undertake larger-scale GRC implementations. A large proportion of the benefits that are available from the full-scale solution option can still be gained via the 'express' solution.

Breadth of GRC requirements coverage represents potential value for extension of adoption

Customers can plan for gradual adoption of more modules or processes across the extensive range of GRC capabilities that MetricStream solutions provide.

Threats

Market consolidation is a threat to independent vendors

MetricStream is established in a leading position across many areas of the GRC market place, and Ovum believes this position to be sustainable given elements of the company's strategy. However, GRC solutions are becoming more and more strategic, and a series of investments by very large vendors seems likely in the future. Customers can lose out in periods of such consolidation as vendor focus changes to integration, rather than maintaining the customer focus and value proposition that provided success in the first place.

Data sheet

Key facts about the solution

Table 1: Data sheet

Product name	MetricStream IT GRC Solution MetricStream GRC Platform	**Product classification**	Governance, Risk and Compliance
Version number	6.1 SP 5	**Release date**	September 2014

Industries covered	Banking and Financial Services Healthcare Pharmaceuticals and Life Sciences Retail and CPG Energy and Utilities Hi-Tech Manufacturing	**Geographies covered**	Global (primary customer base is in US, Europe, and Middle East)
Relevant company sizes	Medium or large companies Deal sizes $50,000 - $1.5M	**Platforms supported**	Microsoft Windows 2003, 2008, 2012 Red Hat Enterprise Linux v6.2, v6.4 SUN Solaris OS 5.10 AIX 6.1
Languages supported	MetricStream supports more than 35 regional languages within the solution including Chinese, Spanish, German, French, Arabic, etc.	**Licensing options**	Perpetual (with annual maintenance and support), or annual subscription. Both on a per-user basis, with categorized user types.
Deployment options	On-premise, On-premise (managed), Hosted (dedicated), SaaS	**Routes to market**	
URL	www.metricstream.com	**Company headquarters**	2600 E. Bayshore Road Palo Alto, CA 94303 USA Tel: +1 650-620-2955
European headquarters	MetricStream UK LTD. 6th Floor One London Wall London United Kingdom EC2Y 5EB Tel: +44-203-318-8554	**North America headquarters**	As above
Asia-Pacific headquarters	AMR Tech Park 2nd B, Near 23,24, AMR Tech Park Internal Rd, Hongasandra, Bangalore, Karnataka 560 068 India Tel: +91 80 4962 8000		

Source: Ovum

Appendix

Methodology

Ovum SWOT Assessments are independent reviews carried out using Ovum's evaluation model for the relevant technology area, supported by conversations with vendors, users, and service providers of the solution concerned, and in-depth secondary research.

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We hope that this analysis will help you make informed and imaginative business decisions. If you have further requirements, Ovum's consulting team may be able to help you. For more information about Ovum's consulting capabilities, please contact us directly at consulting@ovum.com.

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